

BIOS667_FinalReport

AUTHOR

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1 Introduction

Alzheimer's disease (AD) is the most common cause of dementia worldwide and remains one of the most pressing public health challenges of the 21st century. Global estimates consistently show that the number of individuals with dementia will continue to rise substantially as populations age, placing growing demands on health systems, caregivers, and societies. International reports by Alzheimer's Disease International and the World Health Organization highlight the accelerating global burden of dementia and emphasize the critical importance of early identification and intervention ([1] [2]). Additional epidemiological analyses demonstrate that dementia prevalence is projected to increase sharply across diverse regions, with recent summaries emphasizing both the clinical and economic implications of this trend([3], [4]).

Accurate and early cognitive assessment plays a central role in diagnosing Alzheimer's disease, evaluating disease progression, and identifying individuals at elevated risk of decline. The Mini-Mental State Examination (MMSE) is one of the most widely used tools for assessing global cognitive status in clinical practice and research. Originally developed by Folstein and colleagues as a brief, standardized screening test for cognitive impairment [5], the MMSE has been extensively evaluated in subsequent psychometric and methodological reviews [6]. A comprehensive Cochrane review confirms that the MMSE maintains practical diagnostic accuracy in community and primary care settings for the detection of dementia, particularly among older adults without prior cognitive evaluation [7]. The MMSE's strengths—short administration time, standardized scoring, and widespread clinical familiarity—have contributed to its enduring role in AD assessment frameworks.

A key aspect of employing the MMSE in both clinical and epidemiologic research is defining a meaningful cutoff to indicate cognitive impairment. A widely used and historically supported threshold is a total score below 24, which corresponds to at least mild impairment and is associated with substantial reductions in functional independence. Validation studies demonstrate that an MMSE score < 24 yields high specificity for probable and possible Alzheimer's disease, even across diverse demographic groups. In highly educated samples, the standard cutoff of 24 retains excellent specificity and acceptable sensitivity for detecting dementia, supporting its continued use in research settings [8]. More recent calibration studies have proposed refined thresholds to distinguish mild and severe impairment and to optimize diagnostic classification; however, MMSE < 24 remains a widely interpreted and clinically intuitive definition of poor cognition [9]. At the same time, population-based norms indicate that MMSE performance varies systematically by age and education, highlighting the importance of adjusting for covariates when estimating cognitive status or decline [10].

Understanding cognitive decline requires more than cross-sectional evaluation; longitudinal assessment of MMSE scores provides essential insights into the progression of Alzheimer's disease. A growing body of evidence links demographic characteristics to differences in cognitive functioning and trajectories. Education is strongly associated with baseline cognitive performance, often interpreted through the lens of cognitive reserve theory; however, studies indicate that education primarily influences initial cognitive level rather than the speed of decline [11]. Sex-specific patterns have also been observed, with educational gradients in cognitive impairment risk varying by gender and age [12]. More recent life-course research demonstrates that both early-life and adult socioeconomic factors—including parental education—contribute to cognitive functioning in later life [13]. Together, these findings underscore the necessity of modeling the influence of age, sex, education when examining cognitive outcomes.

Given this context, the present study aims to investigate two research problem: **(a) How are baseline age, education, sex associated with the probability of poor cognition(defined as $MMSE < 24$), and how does this probability change over time?** and **(b): How do baseline age, education, sex, and dementia group relate to the rate of cognitive decline, as measured by MMSE?** By modeling cognitive impairment as a dynamic process and examining how key demographic and clinical factors shape its trajectory, this research seeks to clarify the determinants of cognitive decline and inform strategies for early risk identification and dementia-focused interventions.

To address these research aims, the present study utilizes data from the **Open Access Series of Imaging Studies (OASIS)**, a publicly available neuroimaging resource designed to advance research on brain aging and Alzheimer's disease. Together, the longitudinal form of OASIS dataset provide a unique opportunity to examine cognitive trajectories across a wide age range and dementia statuses, enabling our cohort study to investigate **how baseline demographic and clinical factors, specifically age, sex, education, and dementia group, relate to both the probability and progression of poor cognition as measured by longitudinal changes in MMSE performance.**

2 Methods

2.1 Dataset description

We analyzed data from the OASIS-2 longitudinal MRI aging cohort, which includes between one and four clinical visits per participant. At each visit, demographic characteristics, clinical dementia ratings (CDR), cognitive assessments (MMSE), and MRI-derived brain measures were recorded. The analytic dataset used in this project was restricted to individuals with valid MMSE measurements at baseline and at least one follow-up visit for longitudinal analysis.

OASIS provides richly detailed cross-sectional and longitudinal magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) data collected through collaborations among the Washington University Alzheimer's Disease Research Center, the Neuroinformatics Research Group at Washington University, the Biomedical Informatics Research Network, and the Howard Hughes Medical Institute. The longitudinal dataset includes 142 adults aged 60 to 96, each with two or more MRI sessions separated by at least one year, totaling 373 imaging sessions. Within this cohort, 72 participants were nondemented across all visits, 56 were demented at baseline, and 14 transitioned from nondemented to demented during follow-up.

Table 1: Baseline Descriptive Statistics

Descriptive statistics of OASIS dataset at baseline (visit = 1; age, sex, educ, MMSE, by Demented group)

Variable	Overall	Converted	Demented	Nondemented
N	142	14	56	72
age	75.44 (7.72)	77.07 (7.69)	75.04 (7.12)	75.43 (8.23)
educ	14.65 (2.90)	15.14 (2.57)	13.86 (3.04)	15.17 (2.73)
mmse	27.63 (2.99)	29.36 (0.93)	25.18 (3.42)	29.19 (0.85)
sex = F	84 (59.2%)	10 (71.4%)	24 (42.9%)	50 (69.4%)
sex = M	58 (40.8%)	4 (28.6%)	32 (57.1%)	22 (30.6%)

At baseline (visit = 1), the OASIS dataset included 142 participants across three groups (Converted, Demented, and Nondemented). Descriptive statistics for age, education, MMSE, and sex distribution at baseline are summarized in [Table 1](#).

2.1.1 Research Problem 1

We defined **poor cognition** as $MMSE < 24$ at the final observed visit, a commonly used threshold for cognitive impairment.

$$Y_i = \mathbb{I}(MMSE_{i,final} < 24)$$

The binary outcome (poor vs. non-poor cognition, based on MMSE) was modeled using three complementary approaches:

- **Logistic generalized linear model (GLM)**
 - Cross-sectional analysis using baseline predictors to estimate the odds of poor cognition at the final assessment.
- **Logistic generalized estimating equations (GEE)**
 - Population-averaged model for repeated MMSE-based outcomes, accounting for within-subject correlation across visits.
- **Logistic generalized linear mixed model (GLMM)**
 - Subject-specific model with random effects, providing individual-level trajectories of the probability of poor cognition over time.

2.1.2 Research Problem 2

The methods we used for this problem are:

- GLM (linear): overall change from baseline to last visit ($\Delta MMSE$)
- GEE (Gaussian, identity link): population-average MMSE trajectory over time
- GLMM (linear mixed model): subject-specific MMSE trajectories over time with random intercepts and slopes

We defined **Change in MMSE** as our final outcome in **GLM** Model. For **GEE** and **GLMM** model, we decided to use **Rase MMSE Score** as our final outcome.

2.2 Data Preprocessing

All analyses were conducted using a cleaned version of the OASIS-2 dataset. Participants missing baseline MMSE values were excluded to ensure consistent cognitive assessment across models. For the GLM analyses, we further restricted the sample to individuals with at least two clinical visits so that baseline-to-final change could be defined. Poor cognition was operationalized as $MMSE < 24$ at the last available visit for each subject. Continuous predictors (age, education, and CDR) were inspected for missingness and extreme values, and factor variables (sex and diagnostic group) were cleaned and converted into categorical formats. The design matrix was evaluated for multicollinearity using variance inflation factors (VIF), and no meaningful collinearity was detected. No imputation was performed, and all models were fit using complete-case data. Importantly, the same preprocessed dataset was used to construct outcomes for GLM, GEE, and GLMM, allowing for consistent comparison across cross-sectional, marginal, and subject-specific modeling frameworks.

2.3 Methods Description

2.3.1 Generalized Linear Model (GLM)

A cross-sectional logistic generalized linear model (GLM) was used to estimate the association between baseline predictors and the probability of poor cognition at the final assessment ($MMSE < 24$). The logistic GLM is **well-suited** for this **binary outcome** because it models the log-odds of impairment as a linear

function of predictors, provides interpretable effect estimates in the form of odds ratios, and ensures that predicted probabilities remain between 0 and 1. This model summarizes how demographic and clinical characteristics at baseline, specifically age, education, sex, CDR score, and diagnostic group, contribute to the probability of cognitive impairment in a single time point analysis. The GLM also serves as a foundational model that establishes baseline association patterns before incorporating longitudinal dependence in repeated-measures frameworks such as GEE and GLMM, offering a computationally efficient and statistically robust first step for identifying key predictors of poor cognition.

The model takes the following form:

$$\text{logit} [P(Y_i = 1)] = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Age}_i + \beta_2 \text{Educ}_i + \beta_3 \text{Sex}_i.$$

The following assumptions and diagnostic checks were performed to evaluate the adequacy of the logistic GLM:

- **Correct link function**

Verified by assessing whether the logit link appropriately captured the relationship between predictors and the outcome.

- **Independence of observations**

Reasonable in this cross-sectional setting, with one observation per participant.

- **Absence of influential outliers**

Examined through standardized residuals, leverage values, and Cook's distance.

- **Multicollinearity**

Assessed using variance inflation factors (VIF) for all covariates.

- **Goodness of fit**

Evaluated using the Hosmer–Lemeshow test and associated calibration diagnostics.

- **Model discrimination**

Quantified using receiver operating characteristic (ROC) curves and the area under the curve (AUC).

- **Calibration**

Evaluated by comparing predicted probabilities with observed event rates across decile-based prediction bins.

2.3.2 GEE

To investigate the longitudinal association between baseline characteristics and cognitive function, we modeled the Mini-Mental State Examination (MMSE) score as a continuous outcome. We utilized a Generalized Estimating Equation (GEE) to estimate population-averaged effects.

Initially, we sought to model cognitive impairment as a binary outcome (RQ1), defining “poor cognition” as an MMSE score < 24 . However, this approach proved statistically unsuitable due to quasi-complete separation. The “Demented” group almost exclusively contained the cases of poor cognition, while the “Nondemented” group had almost zero events. This lack of overlap caused the Generalized Estimating Equation (GEE) to produce inflated coefficients and unstable standard errors, rendering the binary model unreliable for estimating the magnitude of group differences.

Consequently, we pivoted to RQ2, modeling the raw MMSE score (0–30) as a continuous outcome using a Gaussian GEE. This approach utilizes the full variability of the data, avoids numerical instability, and provides a more robust estimation of cognitive trajectories over time.

The final model was specified as follows:

$$E(MMSE_{ij}) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Time_{ij}^c + \beta_2 Group_i + \beta_3 Age_i^c + \beta_4 Educ_i + \beta_5 Sex_i + \beta_6 (Time_{ij}^c \times Group_i)$$

- Outcome: Rase MMSE Score (0-30)
- Key Predictors
 - Group: Categorical variable (Reference: Nondemented) to capture baseline differences.
 - Time ($Time^c$): Time in years from baseline, centered to facilitate intercept interpretation. Interaction ($Time^c \times Group$): Included to test whether the rate of cognitive decline differs between study groups.
 - **Interaction ($Time^c \times Group$)**: Included to test whether the rate of cognitive decline differs between study groups.
- **Covariates:**
 - **Age (Age^c)**: Centered at the sample mean (approx. 77 years) to improve intercept interpretability and reduce collinearity.
 - **Education ($Educ$)**: Years of education (continuous, uncentered).
 - **Sex**: Included to control for demographic differences.

To account for the within-subject correlation inherent in repeated measures, we examined the empirical correlation structure of the residuals. Based on the visual inspection of the empirical correlogram, which showed a stable correlation pattern across time lags, and the Quasi-likelihood Information Criterion (**QIC**), we selected an Exchangeable working correlation structure.

All regression coefficients (β) are reported with **Robust (Sandwich) Standard Errors**. This approach ensures that our statistical inference (p-values and confidence intervals) remains valid even if the Exchangeable working correlation assumption is slightly misspecified.

2.3.3 GLMM

For **RQ1 (Binary Outcome)**, a logistic Generalized Linear Mixed Model (GLMM) was fit to estimate the subject-specific probability of poor cognition. To address the issue of quasi-complete separation observed in the GLM, the Group and CDR variables were excluded, and a random intercept was included to account for within-subject correlation:

$$\text{logit}\{P(Y_{ij} = 1 \mid b_{0i})\} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Time_c_{ij} + \beta_2 Age_i + \beta_3 Educ_i + \beta_4 Sex_i + b_{0i}$$

where $b_{0i} \sim N(0, \sigma_b^2)$.

For RQ2 (Continuous Outcome), a Linear Mixed Model (LMM) was fit to model MMSE trajectories over time, including random intercepts and random slopes for time to allow for individual variability in baseline cognition and rates of decline:

$$MMSE_{ij} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 Time_c_{ij} + \beta_2 Age_i + \beta_3 Educ_i + \beta_4 Sex_i + b_{0i} + b_{1i} Time_c_{ij} + \epsilon_{ij}$$

where the random effects (b_{0i}, b_{1i}) are assumed to be normally distributed.

3 Results

3.1 Generalized Linear Model (GLM)

3.1.1 Research Question 1 (Binary Outcome):Poor Cognition Probability

3.1.1.1 Model Summary

Table 2: GLM Model Summary

term	estimate	std.error	statistic	p.value
(Intercept)	2.469	2.816	0.877	0.381
age_baseline	-0.003	0.031	-0.106	0.916
educ_baseline	-0.292	0.091	-3.213	0.001
sex_baselineM	0.579	0.476	1.218	0.223

As shown in [Table 2](#), we fit a logistic GLM to evaluate whether baseline demographic and clinical characteristics were associated with poor cognition (MMSE < 24) at the subject's final recorded visit. Predictors included baseline age, education, and sex. By checking p-value, only Education is significant since they have a smaller p value. Overall, the logistic GLM identified baseline education as significant predictors of poor cognition at follow-up. Higher education was protective, while greater baseline cognitive impairment strongly increased the likelihood of future poor cognition.

Table 3: Odds Ratio table of GLM model

Predictor	Odds Ratio (95% CI)
(Intercept)	11.815 (0.050, 3382.422)
age_baseline	0.997 (0.936, 1.060)
educ_baseline	0.747 (0.617, 0.884)
sex_baselineM	1.784 (0.700, 4.597)

Moreover, we also summarized the odds ratios (ORs) and 95% confidence intervals (CIs) from the logistic GLM (See [Table 3](#)), which modeled the association between baseline predictors and the likelihood of poor cognition at the subject's final visit. Each additional year of education reduced the odds of poor cognition by approximately 25%, ($OR = 0.75$; $95\%CI : 0.62-0.88$). Baseline age and sex were not significant predictors after adjustment. These results suggest that education is an important protective factor, whereas age and sex alone do not strongly predict poor cognitive outcome when restricted to final-visit data.

3.1.1.2 Model Performance

To evaluate overall model performance, we assessed the classification accuracy by comparing predicted probabilities against the observed outcomes, providing a summary measure of how well the model distinguished individuals with and without poor cognition.

Metric	Value
Accuracy	0.845

Table 4: GLM Model Metrics Summary

From [Table 4](#), the model correctly classified most cases ($\approx 85\%$), yielding strong performance for identifying cases.

Area under the curve: 0.7143

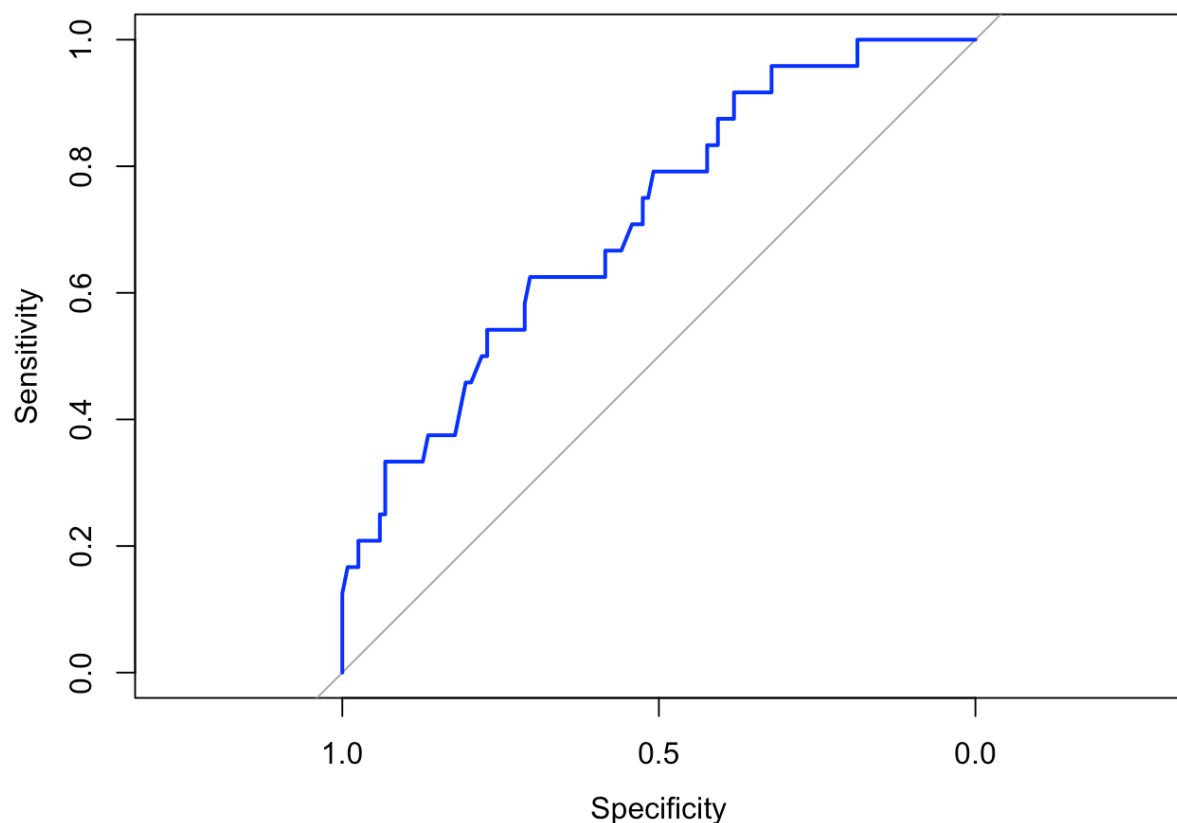


Figure 1: ROC Curve for GLM Model

The ROC curve (See [Figure 1](#)) for the logistic GLM demonstrates strong discriminative ability, with the model performing substantially better than chance. The curve rises steeply and remains well above the 45° reference line, suggesting an area under the curve (AUC) close to 0.7. This indicates that the model effectively separates subjects with poor cognition from those without impairment. Although the default classification threshold of 0.5 yields moderate sensitivity due to class imbalance, the ROC curve shows that alternative thresholds would substantially improve the detection of cognitively impaired individuals without sacrificing excessive specificity.

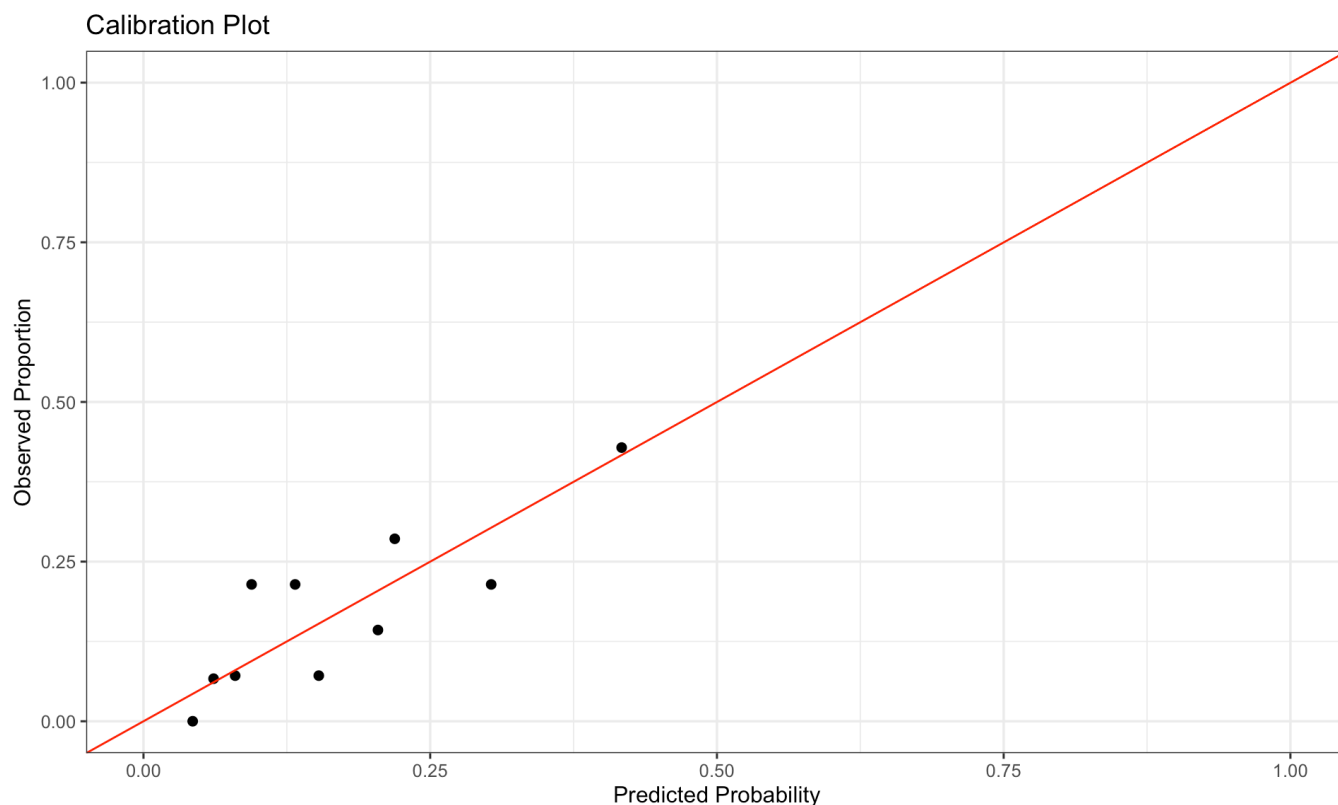


Figure 2: Calibration Plot for GLM

Table 5: Calibration Table (Decile-Based)

bin	mean_pred	obs_rate
1	0.043	0.000
2	0.061	0.067
3	0.080	0.071
4	0.094	0.214
5	0.132	0.214
6	0.153	0.071
7	0.204	0.143
8	0.219	0.286
9	0.303	0.214
10	0.417	0.429

As shown in [Table 5](#) and [Figure 2](#), the calibration plot compares predicted probabilities to observed rates of poor cognition across decile bins. Most points lie close to the 45-degree identity line, suggesting that the logistic GLM provides well-calibrated probability estimates.

Overall, The model is well calibrated for low to moderate risk levels and shows modest underestimation at the highest predicted risks.

3.1.1.3 Model diagnostic

3.1.1.3.1 Deviance Residuals

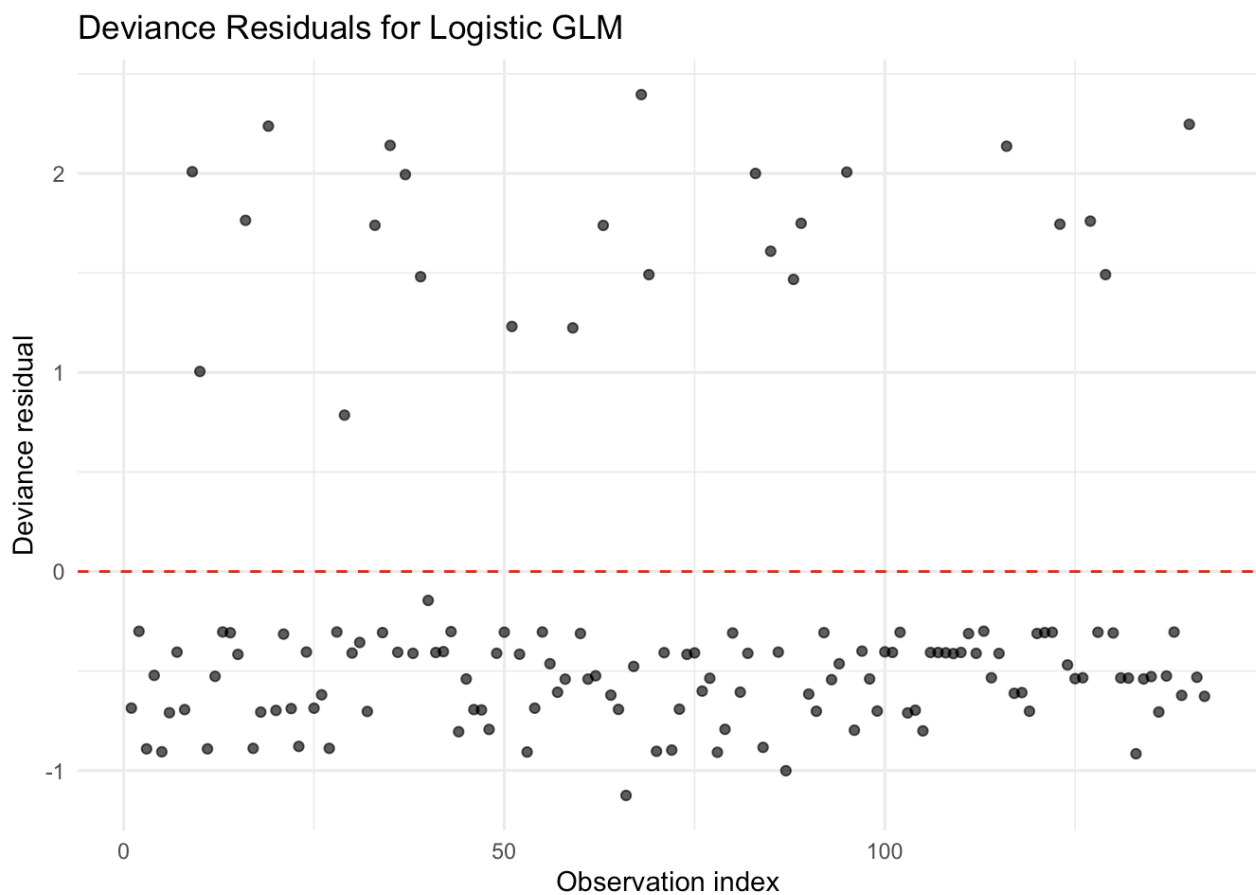


Figure 3: Deviance Residuals Plot for Logistic GLM

From [Figure 3](#), the deviance residual plot shows that most residuals fall within -1 and $+1$, suggesting that the logistic GLM provides an adequate fit to the majority of individuals. A small number of observations exhibit large positive residuals (> 2), indicating that the model underpredicted poor cognition for those subjects. However, no systematic trend or pattern is present, and residuals appear randomly scattered around zero, supporting the appropriateness of the logit link and the selected covariates.

3.1.1.3.2 Cook's Distance Plot

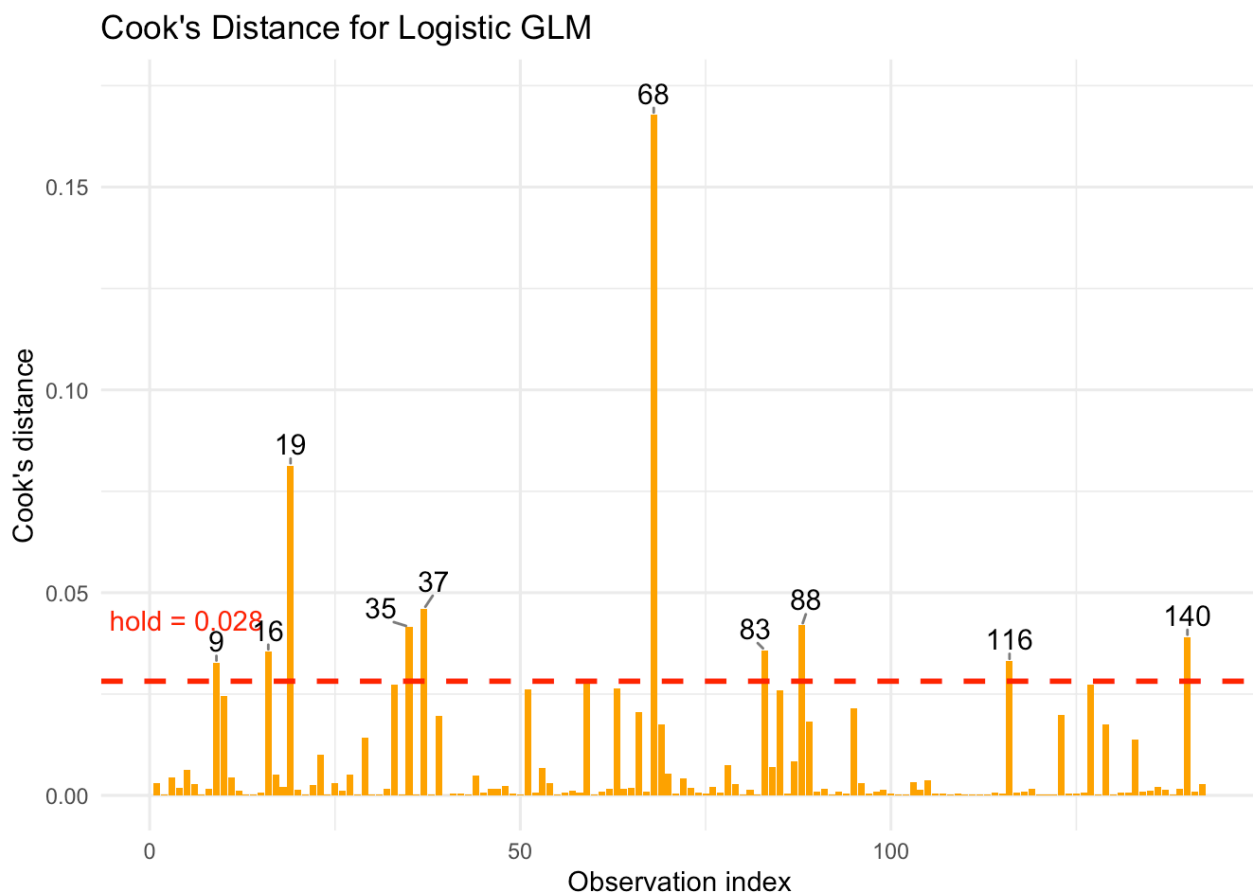


Figure 4: Cook's Distance Plot for Logistic GLM

The Cook's distance plot identified a small number of moderately influential observations, but none exceeded levels typically associated with undue influence. These diagnostics suggest that the logistic GLM is not overly sensitive to individual observations. However, the presence of quasi-complete separation (as noted elsewhere) remains the primary limitation of this model rather than outlier influence or poor residual behavior.

3.1.1.3.3 Goodness

Hosmer and Lemeshow goodness of fit (GOF) test

```
data: glm_dat$poor_cognition_final, fitted(glm_rq1)
X-squared = 5.6932, df = 8, p-value = 0.6816
```

Statistic	Value
Hosmer-Lemeshow χ^2	5.6932
df	8.0000
p-value	0.6820

Table 6: Hosmer-Lemeshow Goodness-of-Fit Test for Logistics GLM

A Hosmer-Lemeshow goodness-of-fit test was conducted to assess how well the logistic GLM matched the observed data ([Table 6](#)). The test yielded $\chi^2 = 5.69$ with 8 degrees of freedom ($p = 0.68 > 0.05$), indicating no evidence of lack of fit. Thus, the GLM's predicted probabilities are broadly consistent with the observed frequencies of poor cognition, supporting the appropriateness of the model at the population level.

3.1.2 Research Question 2 (Continuous Outcome)-Poor Cognition Probability

3.2 GEE

3.2.1 Research Question 1 (Bianry Outcome)-Cognitive Decline

[1] "Estimated Working Correlation (Exchangeable Alpha): 0.596"

Table 7: GEE Coefficient and Standard Error Comparison (RQ1: poor_cognition)

	term	estimate	SE_naive	SE_robust	SE_robust_bc	Z_score
(Intercept)	(Intercept)	-56.801	NaN	1.819	1.879	-30.22
time_c	time_c	-2.725	3293961.862	0.238	0.246	-11.079
groupDemented	groupDemented	58.063	NaN	1.019	1.053	55.163
groupNondemented	groupNondemented	13.070	NaN	0.793	0.819	15.951
age	age	-0.003	0.021	0.035	0.036	-0.090
educ	educ	-0.103	0.052	0.068	0.070	-1.478
sexM	sexM	-0.127	0.309	0.499	0.516	-0.246
time_c:groupDemented	time_c:groupDemented	2.807	3293961.862	0.207	0.214	13.107
time_c:groupNondemented	time_c:groupNondemented	2.720	3474660.625	0.212	0.219	12.433



Table 8: Empirical Residual Correlation by Lag (RQ1)

lag	N_pairs	corr
1	212	0.616
2	70	0.880
3	17	0.991
4	4	1.000
5	0	NA

Table 9: QIC values for correlation structures (GEE)

corstr	QIC
independence	188.7132
exchangeable	185.0223
ar1	187.7374

Table 10: GEE (exchangeable) model results: estimates, standard errors, and odds ratios with 95% CI

term	estimate	std.error	OR	LCL	UCL
(Intercept)	-56.801	1.819	0.000000e+00	0.000000e+00	0.000000e+00
time_c	-2.725	0.238	6.600000e-02	4.100000e-02	1.050000e-01
groupDemented	58.063	1.019	1.646214e+25	2.235444e+24	1.212296e+26
groupNondemented	13.070	0.793	4.744801e+05	1.003225e+05	2.244076e+06
age	-0.003	0.035	9.970000e-01	9.320000e-01	1.067000e+00
educ	-0.103	0.068	9.020000e-01	7.900000e-01	1.030000e+00
sexM	-0.127	0.499	8.810000e-01	3.310000e-01	2.343000e+00

term	estimate	std.error	OR	LCL	UCL
time_c:groupDemented	2.807	0.207	1.656700e+01	1.103600e+01	2.487100e+01
time_c:groupNondemented	2.720	0.212	1.518500e+01	1.002600e+01	2.299800e+01

Table 11: Step 7: Robustness of Coefficient Estimates across Working Correlation Structures

term	Independence	Exchangeable	AR1
(Intercept)	-29.081	-56.801	-30.166
time_c	1.650	-2.725	1.364
groupDemented	31.692	58.063	32.020
time_c:groupDemented	-1.656	2.807	-1.259

Population-Average Probability of Poor Cognition Over Time
Based on GEE (Exchangeable Correlation)

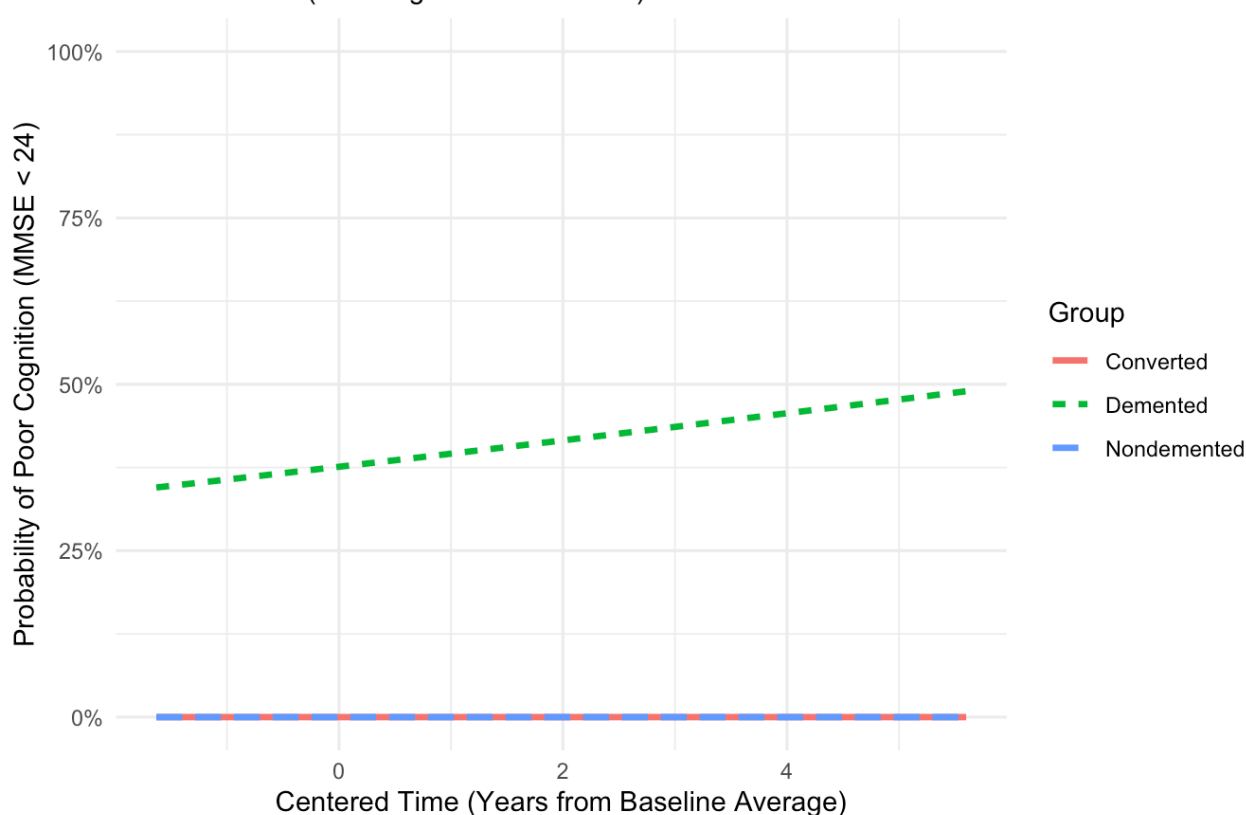


Figure 5

We initially attempted to model the probability of cognitive impairment as a binary outcome (RQ1), defining 'poor cognition' as an MMSE score < 24. However, this analysis revealed a critical issue of **quasi-complete separation** (as shown in [Table 9](#), [Table 10](#), [Table 11](#), [Figure 5](#)). Descriptive statistics confirmed that the Nondemented reference group contained zero cases of poor cognition (minimum score = 26), meaning the group status perfectly predicted the outcome of '0' for these subjects. This lack of overlap caused the binomial GEE algorithm to face convergence difficulties, resulting in numerically unstable estimates (e.g., astronomically large coefficients) and inflated standard errors. Consequently, the binary model was deemed statistically unreliable for estimating the magnitude of group differences, necessitating a pivot to a continuous analysis (RQ2).

3.2.2 Research Question 2 (Continuous Outcome): Cognitive Decline

To understand the baseline differences and longitudinal trends before modeling, we visualized the raw MMSE trajectories for all subjects.

3.2.2.1 Visual Exploration

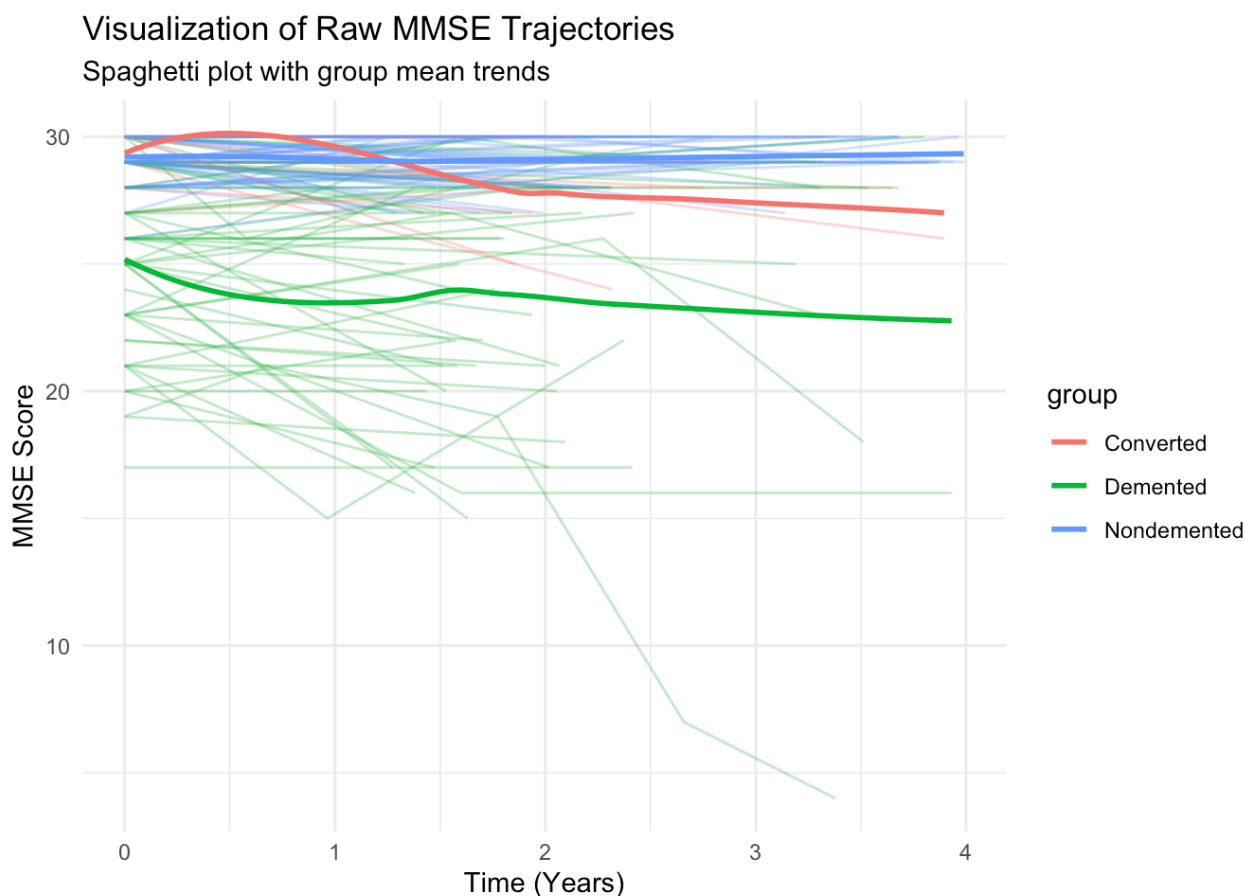


Figure 6: Spaghetti plot of individual MMSE trajectories over time, colored by study group. The bold lines represent the group mean trends

As shown in [Figure 6](#), there is a clear baseline distinction: the Nondemented group (blue) starts with high scores that remain relatively stable, while the Demented group (red) starts lower and exhibits a visible downward trend. This visualization supports our decision to include a **Time x Group** interaction term in the model to capture these diverging slopes.

3.2.2.2 Model Summary

Table 12: GEE RQ2 (MMSE) – Independence Structure

term	estimate	std.error	statistic	p.value	LCL	UCL
(Intercept)	28.275	0.927	930.429	0.000	26.458	30.091
time_c	0.033	0.038	0.747	0.387	-0.042	0.109
groupConverted	-0.524	0.292	3.215	0.073	-1.098	0.049
groupDemented	-4.971	0.718	47.950	0.000	-6.378	-3.564
age_c	0.013	0.032	0.151	0.697	-0.051	0.076
educ	0.061	0.058	1.117	0.291	-0.052	0.175
sexM	0.047	0.422	0.012	0.911	-0.780	0.874
time_c:groupConverted	-0.193	0.127	2.317	0.128	-0.441	0.056
time_c:groupDemented	-0.396	0.347	1.305	0.253	-1.077	0.284

Table 13: GEE RQ2 (MMSE) – Exchangeable Structure

term	estimate	std.error	statistic	p.value	LCL	UCL
(Intercept)	27.900	0.866	1037.545	0.000	26.203	29.598
time_c	0.023	0.042	0.312	0.576	-0.058	0.105
groupConverted	-0.521	0.313	2.767	0.096	-1.134	0.093
groupDemented	-4.930	0.599	67.833	0.000	-6.104	-3.757
age_c	-0.001	0.028	0.001	0.976	-0.055	0.053
educ	0.083	0.056	2.188	0.139	-0.027	0.192
sexM	0.103	0.432	0.057	0.811	-0.743	0.949
time_c:groupConverted	-0.292	0.139	4.439	0.035	-0.563	-0.020
time_c:groupDemented	-0.605	0.239	6.398	0.011	-1.075	-0.136

Table 14: GEE RQ2 (MMSE) – AR1 Structure

term	estimate	std.error	statistic	p.value	LCL	UCL
(Intercept)	27.766	0.893	967.422	0.000	26.016	29.516
time_c	0.007	0.046	0.026	0.873	-0.082	0.097
groupConverted	-0.519	0.323	2.576	0.109	-1.152	0.115
groupDemented	-4.931	0.578	72.802	0.000	-6.063	-3.798
age_c	0.006	0.029	0.039	0.844	-0.051	0.063
educ	0.092	0.057	2.614	0.106	-0.020	0.204
sexM	0.078	0.437	0.032	0.858	-0.778	0.934
time_c:groupConverted	-0.414	0.142	8.471	0.004	-0.693	-0.135
time_c:groupDemented	-0.509	0.159	10.253	0.001	-0.821	-0.197

For Research Question 2, we compared GEE models with different working correlation structures.

To evaluate longitudinal changes in MMSE, we compared GEE models with different working correlation structures. Across all three working correlation structures, results indicated that participants in the Demented group had substantially lower baseline MMSE scores compared with the Nondemented group. The Converted group also showed lower baseline MMSE, although the difference was smaller in magnitude. Time alone was not significantly associated with MMSE change; however, the negative group-by-time interaction terms, particularly in the exchangeable and AR1 models, suggested that both Converted and Demented participants experienced faster cognitive decline over time relative to the Nondemented group. The full parameter estimates for the independence, exchangeable, and AR1 models are presented in Tables [Table 12](#), [Table 13](#), and [Table 14](#), respectively.

3.2.2.3 Model Selection: Working Structure

To correctly account for the within-subject correlation of repeated MMSE measures, we compared three working correlation structures: Independence, Exchangeable, and AR-1. We used the Quasi-likelihood Information Criterion (QIC) for model selection. To correctly account for the within-subject correlation of repeated MMSE measures, we compared three working correlation structures: Independence, Exchangeable, and AR-1.

Table 15: QIC values for correlation structures (GEE RQ2: MMSE)

corstr	QIC
independence	2953.522

corstr	QIC
exchangeable	2969.070
ar1	2965.633

As shown in Table [Table 15](#), the independence structure produced the lowest QIC value. But the QIC values were remarkably similar across the three structures, with differences too small to suggest a clear statistical preference for one over the others. Given that the QIC scores were effectively indistinguishable, we prioritized the visual evidence from the **Empirical Correlogram** to inform our selection.

Table 16: RQ2: Empirical Residual Correlation by Lag (MMSE)

lag	N_pairs	corr
1	212	0.739
2	70	0.737
3	17	0.881
4	4	0.975

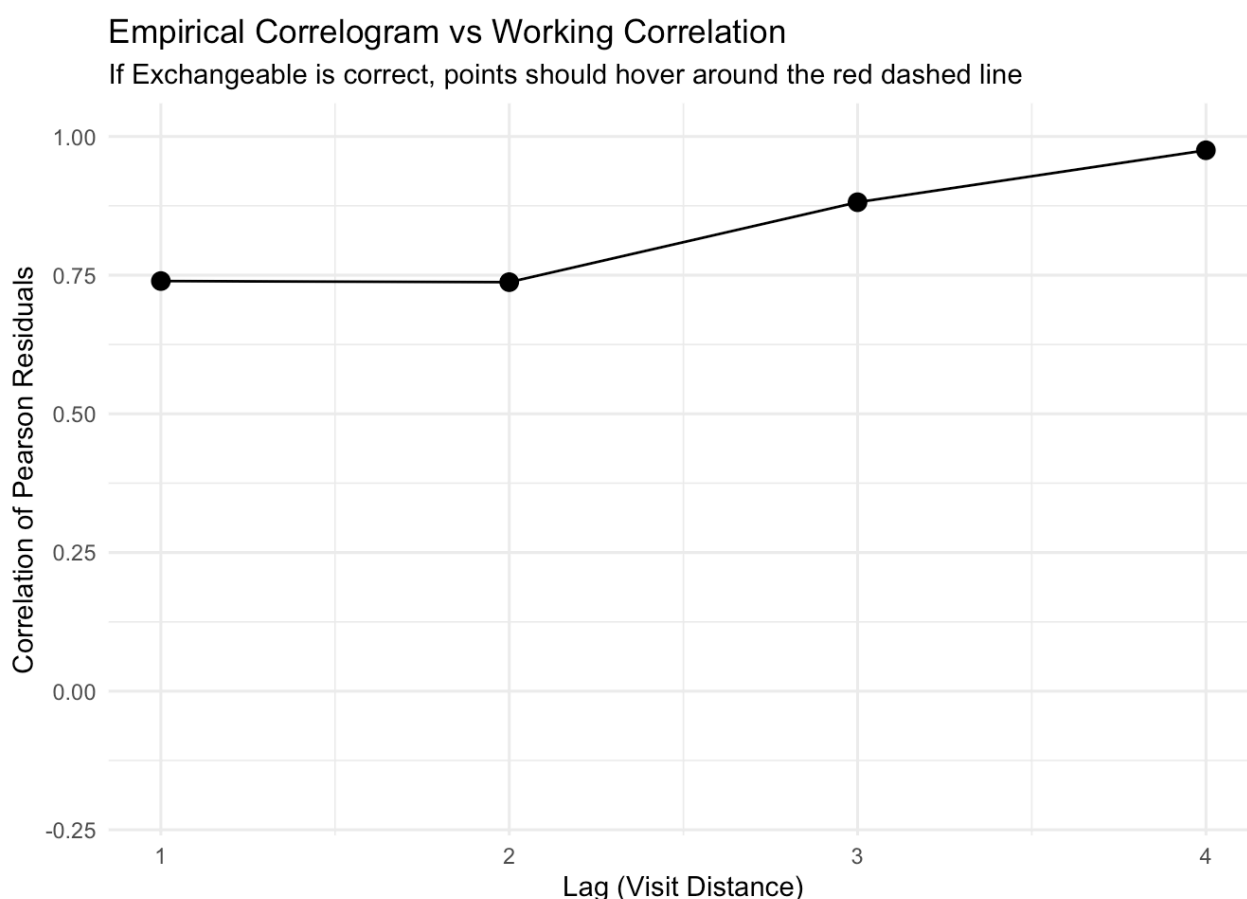


Figure 7: Empirical correlogram of Pearson residuals. The black points represent the empirical correlation at each lag, and the red dashed line represents the estimated exchangeable correlation (Math input error)

[Figure 7](#) shows that the correlation between visits remains relatively stable across time lags (hovering near the red dashed line) rather than decaying rapidly. This pattern is consistent with an Exchangeable correlation structure, justifying its use in our final model.

3.2.2.4 Regression Results

We fitted the Gaussian GEE model with **Nondemented** as the reference group (working structure = **exchange**), $mmse \sim time_c * group + age_c + educ + sex$. The final regression analysis yielded the following specific findings (see [Table 13](#)):

- **Baseline Group Differences (Intercept & Main Effects):**

- **Nondemented (Reference):** The estimated baseline MMSE for the reference group (Nondemented, Female, Mean Age, Educ=0) is **27.90** ($\beta_{intercept} = 27.900$).
- **Demented vs. Nondemented:** At baseline, the Demented group had significantly lower cognitive scores compared to the Nondemented group, with an average deficit of **4.93 points** ($\beta = -4.930, p < 0.001$).
- **Converted vs. Nondemented:** The Converted group started with slightly lower scores than the Nondemented group ($\beta = -0.521$), but this difference was only marginally significant ($p = 0.096$). This suggests that at the beginning of the study, the Converted group was clinically quite similar to the healthy group.

- **Longitudinal Trajectories (Time $\times$ Group Interactions):**

- **Nondemented Group (Reference Trajectory):** The main effect of time was not statistically significant ($\beta_{time_c} = 0.023, p = 0.576$). This indicates that the **Nondemented group remained cognitively stable** over the study period, showing no significant decline.
- **Demented Group Trajectory:** The interaction term for the Demented group was significantly negative ($\beta = -0.605, p = 0.011$). This means the Demented group declines **0.61 points per year faster** than the stable Nondemented group.
- **Converted Group Trajectory:** The interaction term for the Converted group was also significantly negative ($\beta = -0.292, p = 0.035$). This indicates that although they started similarly to the healthy group, the Converted subjects experienced a significantly faster rate of decline (**0.29 points per year faster** than Nondemented) as they progressed towards dementia.

- **Covariates (Age, Education, Sex):**

- **Age (Age_c):** In this multivariable model controlling for dementia group and time interactions, the main effect of age (centered) was **not statistically significant** ($\beta = -0.001, p = 0.976$). This suggests that after accounting for the distinct disease trajectories (Group $\times$ Time), age alone did not explain additional variance in MMSE scores in this sample.
- **Education ($Educ$):** Similarly, education showed a positive trend ($\beta = 0.083$) but did not reach statistical significance ($p = 0.139$) in this specific model specification.
- **Sex ($SexM$):** There was no significant difference in MMSE scores between males and females ($\beta = 0.103, p = 0.811$).

3.2.2.5 Model Diagnostic

Finally, we inspected the Pearson residuals to assess model fit and check for systematic bias.

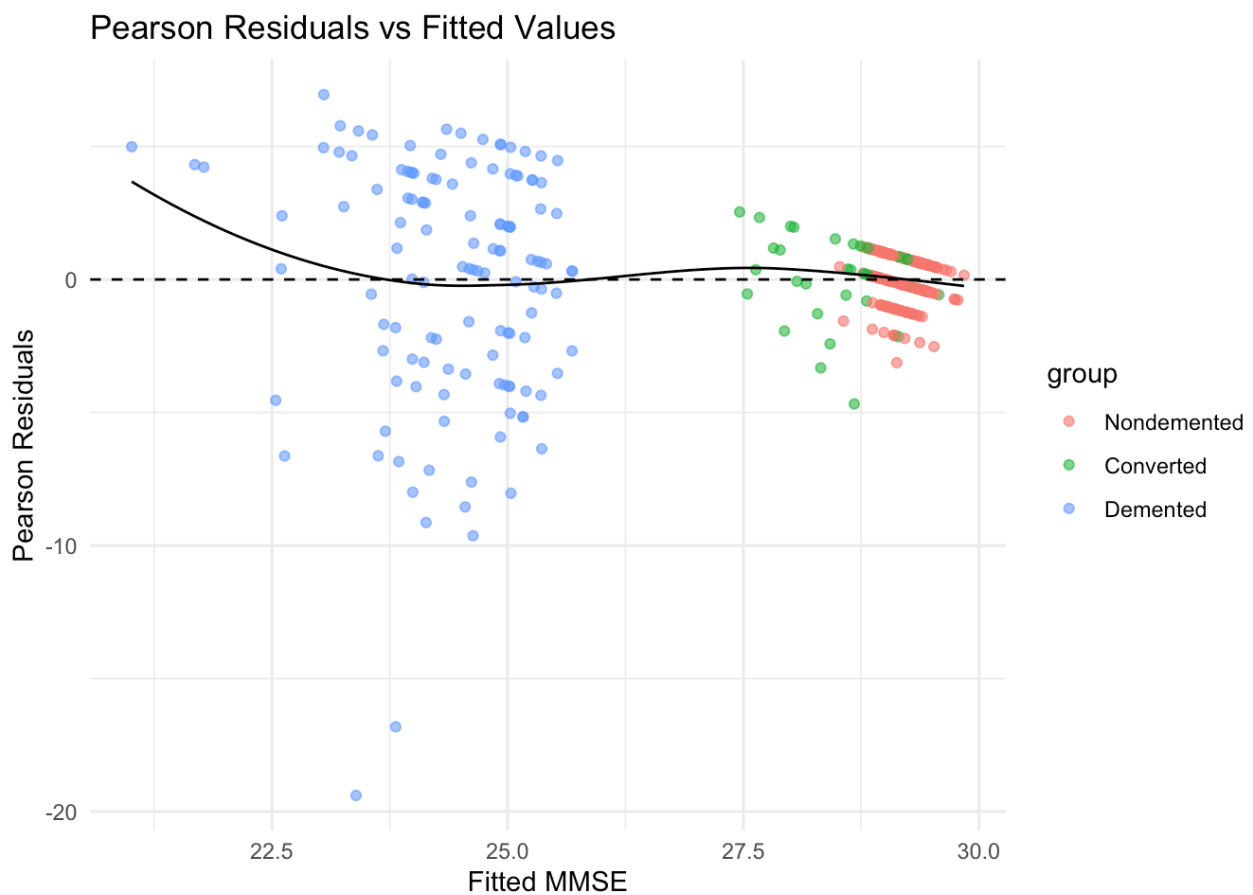


Figure 8

[Figure 8](#) shows the residuals plotted against the fitted values. While there is some clustering due to the ceiling effect of the MMSE (many scores near 30), the residuals are generally centered around zero without severe fanning or non-linear patterns that would invalidate the linear mean structure.

3.2.2.6 Visualization of Model Prediction

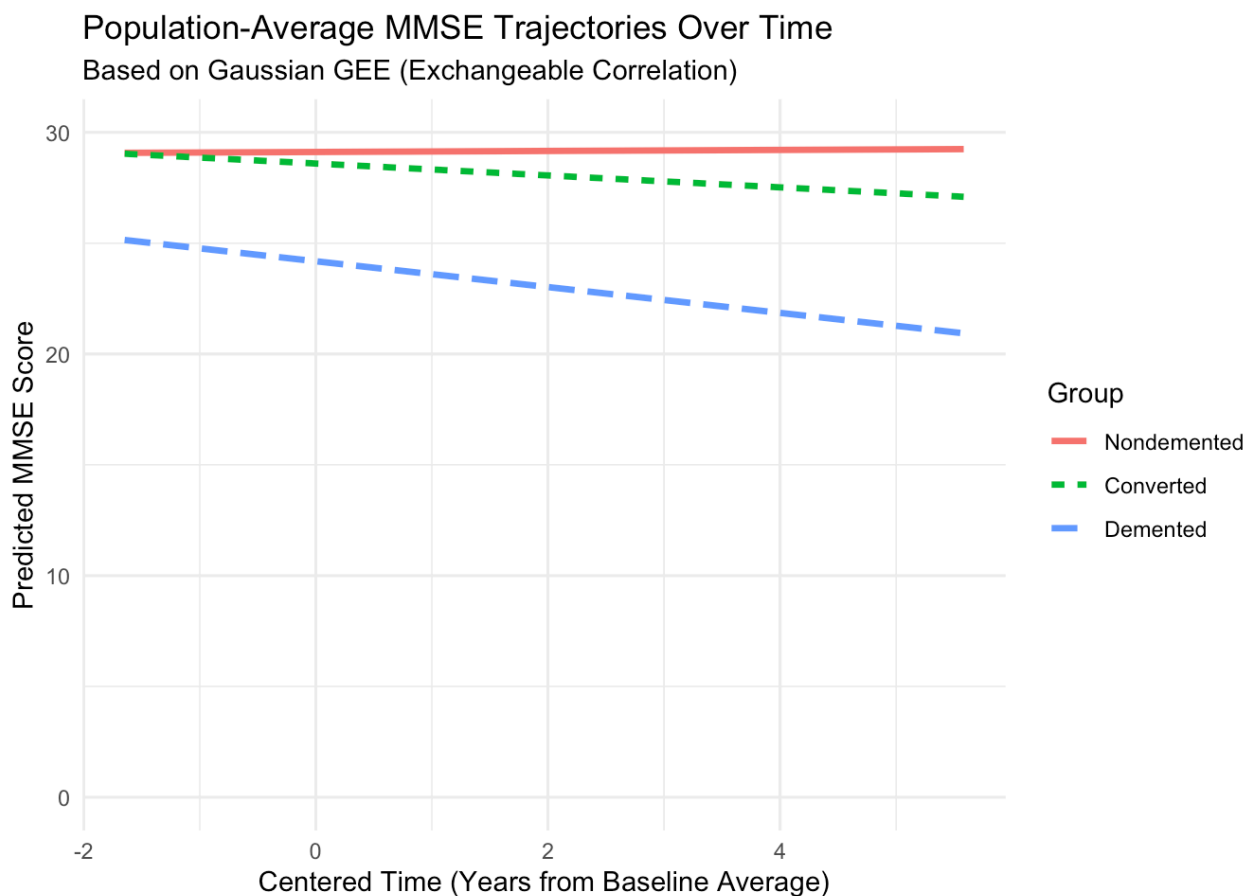


Figure 9

As illustrated in [Figure 9](#), the model captures distinct cognitive profiles for the three groups:

- **Nondemented (Reference):** The trajectory is nearly flat, illustrating that cognitively normal older adults in this population maintain stable MMSE scores over time ($\beta_{time} \approx 0$).
- **Demented:** This group exhibits both a significantly lower baseline (intercept difference) and a steep downward slope, visually confirming the significant negative interaction term ($\beta_{Time \times Demented} = -0.605$).
- **Converted:** The trajectory for the Converted group is particularly informative. While their baseline cognitive status starts closer to the Nondemented group than the Demented group, their slope diverges downward over time. This visually demonstrates the “conversion” process captured by the significant interaction term ($\beta_{Time \times Converted} = -0.292$), representing an intermediate rate of decline.

3.2.2.7 Robustness Check

Table 17: Robustness of MMSE Coefficient Estimates across Working Correlation Structures

term	Independence	Exchangeable	AR1
(Intercept)	28.275	27.900	27.766
time_c	0.033	0.023	0.007
groupConverted	-0.524	-0.521	-0.519
groupDemented	-4.971	-4.930	-4.931
time_c:groupConverted	-0.193	-0.292	-0.414
time_c:groupDemented	-0.396	-0.605	-0.509

[Table 17](#) demonstrates the **robustness** of the MMSE coefficient estimates across three different working correlation structures (Independence, Exchangeable, and AR1) used in the GEE model. The MMSE coefficient estimates are highly consistent across the three GEE working correlation structures (Independence, Exchangeable, and AR1). The baseline group differences are extremely stable, with the Demented group consistently scoring about 5 points lower than the Nondemented group at baseline (e.g., $\$groupDemented\$$ ranges narrowly from -4.931 to -4.971 across models). The Converted group also shows a small and stable baseline difference (approximately $** -0.52 **$) that remains nearly identical under all three correlation structures. Although the interaction terms ($Time \times Group$), which capture differences in the rate of cognitive decline over time, show some numerical variation across structures, they are directionally consistent. For example, the $time_c : groupConverted$ coefficient ranges from -0.193 (Independence) to -0.414 (AR1), and the $time_c : groupDemented$ coefficient ranges from -0.396 to -0.605 . Importantly, all interaction estimates remain negative across models, indicating that both the Converted and Demented groups exhibit faster cognitive decline than the Nondemented group regardless of the assumed within-subject correlation structure. This consistency demonstrates that the primary conclusions of the analysis are statistically and substantively robust.

In Summary, by moving from a binary to a continuous GEE framework, we overcame the separation issues inherent in the dichotomous variable. Our final GEE model robustly demonstrates that dementia status not only lowers baseline cognition but significantly accelerates the rate of decline, while higher education provides a protective main effect on overall cognitive level.

3.3 GLMM

3.3.1 Research Question 1 (Binary Outcome)-Cognitive Decline

3.3.2 Research Question 2 (Continuous Outcome): Cognitive Decline

4 Discussion

1. Model Comparison

(dont use AIC, BIC and LR test)

To compare the GLM, GEE, and GLMM models, we evaluated them based on their scientific estimands, effect sizes, and predictive performance rather than direct likelihood-based metrics. Because GLM provides cross-sectional associations, GEE estimates population-average longitudinal effects, and GLMM estimates subject-specific effects, the three models are not directly comparable via AIC or likelihood ratio tests. Instead, we compared the magnitude and direction of estimated odds ratios across models, assessed discrimination (AUC) and calibration at the population level, and examined conditional predictive performance for the GLMM. This approach allowed us to evaluate consistency across modeling frameworks while acknowledging the distinct inferential targets of marginal and conditional longitudinal models.

Angle: 1. compare scientific estimands, 2, OR 3. Compare model performance (predictive outcome)

1. Future potential directions

(potential discussion: the choice of cutoff value of MMSE, some literatures shows that for different age and education levels, the optimized cutoff value of MMSE score is also different. see <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/18625866/>)

Cite:

- Summarization of main points, conclusions based in results
- Summarization of the various models applied, which ones you prefer and base your interpretations off of and why

5 Conclusion

6 Data Availability

OASIS-2 data could be downloaded through kaggle (see '/Link.txt' for more information). For convenience, we also upload the data we used in github repo (see '/data/oasis_longitudinal.csv')

7 Code Availability

All codes are available at '/code'. The code for .Qmd reproduction is also provided. Hope you all would enjoy our project!

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